him; even Shamsuddin, who had no love lost for Maham's son, 'rose half-up'. Adham strode up to Shamsuddin, hand on his dagger, and snapped at his crew, 'Why do you stand still?'[46]

One of the men stabbed Shamsuddin in the chest. Shocked yet still alive, Akbar's ataka staggered out of the door into the courtyard. Another of Adham's men slashed at him with his sword. Twice.

Shamsuddin of Ghazni, who dreamt of the moon in his arms, the farmer's son who became imperial vakil in Hindustan, fell to the ground, butchered in the palace of the foster child he had served and protected from the day that Akbar was born.

Akbar couldn't believe it; 'he asked again'.[47]

Rafiq pointed at the dead man.

And Adham Khan? He had rushed upstairs, 'sword in hand'.[48] Even now, he was standing at the door to the harem, locked just in time by its guard, demanding to be let in.

In a blaze of fury, Akbar went to Adham, though not through the door at which Adham stood. He took another way, not even bothering to pick up his sword – a servant gave him the weapon as he walked past.

'Spoiled child,' he cried, from behind Adham, 'why did you kill our ataka?'

This is the translation that William M. Thackston, most recent translator of the *Akbarnama*, offers, but it is hardly satisfactory. Other translators have alternatives. '*Bacha-i-laada*' is what Akbar said; he might have meant 'son of a fool' (Beveridge) or, perhaps, 'son of a bitch' (Blochmann). Only Bayazid Biyat, the old soldier, has Akbar swearing in properly and unambiguously filthy terms at the man who had just killed his foster father. '*Kandu!*' – or *gandu* – he screamed. 'Assfucker! Why did you kill my ataka?'[49]

Adham Khan rushed to Akbar and grabbed his hands. What did he mean to do, to say? Did he want to explain? Akbar let his own sword fall, wrenched his hands free and reached for Adham's blade, just as Adham, too, grabbed at it. Would he really have stabbed his padishah?

We will never know. As Adham took up his sword, Akbar let go of the weapon. He did not need sharp edges and polished steel. He had his fury. He made a fist.